Outcomes of Democracy

The big idea

Most countries in the world today claim to be democracies. But how do we judge whether democracy actually **delivers**? This chapter evaluates democracy on what we can reasonably expect from it: an **accountable, responsive and legitimate government**, **economic growth and development**, **reduction of inequality and poverty**, **accommodation of social diversity**, and **dignity and freedom of citizens**. The answer is balanced: democracy is not a magic solution, but it is better than any alternative we know.

WHY DEMOCRACY IS PREFERRED

Democracy (1) promotes **equality among citizens**, (2) enhances the **dignity of the individual**, (3) **improves the quality of decision-making**, (4) provides a method to **resolve conflicts**, and (5) allows room to **correct mistakes**.

How do we assess democracy's outcomes?

We must not expect democracy to solve every problem. Democracy is only a **form of government**; it can create conditions for achieving something, and citizens must take advantage of those conditions. The fact that people complain about democracy is itself a testimony to its success: it shows that people have developed awareness and the ability to look critically at power holders.

Accountable, responsive and legitimate government

Accountable. Democracy ensures that decision-making is based on **norms and procedures**. A citizen who wants to know if a decision was taken through the correct procedures can find out. This is called **transparency**: the right and means

to examine the process of decisions. (In India, the **Right to Information** Act gives citizens such a means.) Democratic governments may be **slower** than dictatorships because they follow procedures, deliberate and negotiate, but their decisions are more acceptable and more effective. So the **cost of time** is worth paying.

Responsive. Democracy should produce a government that attends to the needs and expectations of people. Here the record is mixed: democracies often frustrate the needs of people and ignore the demands of a majority of the population. But they are better than non-democratic regimes at holding regular, free and fair elections and allowing open public debate on major policies.

LEGITIMATE GOVERNMENT

Democratic government is a **legitimate government**. It may be slow, less efficient, not always very responsive or clean, but it is **people's own government**. That is why there is overwhelming support for the idea of democracy all over the world, and people wish to be ruled by representatives elected by them.

Economic growth and development

If we consider all democracies and all dictatorships for the fifty years between **1950 and 2000**, **dictatorships have a slightly higher rate of economic growth**.

Regime type (1950–2000)	Average rate of growth (%)
All democratic regimes	**3.95**
All dictatorial regimes	**4.42**
Poor countries under dictatorship	4.34
Poor countries under democracy	4.28

Economic development depends on several factors: the country's **population size, global situation, cooperation from other countries, economic priorities adopted** by the country, etc. The difference in rates of growth between less developed countries under dictatorship and democracy is **negligible**. Overall, we cannot say democracy is a guarantee of economic development, but we can expect it not to lag behind dictatorships. Given its other positive outcomes, democracy is a better choice even though it may not deliver faster growth.

Reduction of inequality and poverty

Democracies are based on **political equality**: all individuals have equal weight in electing representatives (one person, one vote). But alongside the process of bringing individuals into the political arena on an equal footing, we find **growing economic inequalities**. A small number of ultra-rich enjoy a highly disproportionate share of wealth and incomes. Those at the bottom of society have very little to depend upon; their incomes have been declining. Sometimes they find it difficult to meet their basic needs of life: food, clothing, house, education and health.

In actual life, democracies do not appear to be very successful in reducing economic inequalities. The poor constitute a large proportion of our voters, and no party will like to lose their votes, yet democratically elected governments do not appear to be as keen to address the question of poverty as you would expect them to. The situation is much worse in some other countries; for example, in **Bangladesh**, more than half its population lived in poverty (NCERT example).

"DEMOCRACY HAS REMOVED INEQUALITY"

No. Democracy gives **political equality**, but **economic inequality** has often grown in democracies. Write this honestly in answers; examiners reward balanced points.

Accommodation of social diversity

Democracies usually develop a procedure to conduct their competition. This **reduces the possibility of tensions** becoming explosive or violent. No society can fully and permanently resolve conflicts among different groups, but we can learn to respect these differences and evolve mechanisms to negotiate them. Democracy is best suited to produce this outcome. **Belgium** has successfully negotiated differences among ethnic populations; **Sri Lanka**, by contrast, shows what happens when the majority refuses to accommodate.

TWO CONDITIONS FOR ACCOMMODATION

1. **Democracy is not simply rule by majority opinion.** The majority always needs to work with the minority so that governments function to represent the general view. Majority and minority opinions are **not permanent**.
2. **Rule by majority does not become rule by majority community** in terms of religion, race or linguistic groups. Democracy remains democracy only as long as **every citizen has a chance of being in the majority at some point of time**. If someone is barred from being in the majority on the basis of birth, the democratic rule ceases to be accommodative for that person or group.

Dignity and freedom of the citizens

Democracy stands much superior to any other form of government in promoting **dignity and freedom of the individual**. Every individual wants to receive respect from fellow beings. Conflicts often arise among individuals because some feel they are not treated with due respect.

- **Dignity of women**: most societies across the world were historically **male-dominated**. Long struggles by women have created some sensitivity today that respect to and equal treatment of women are necessary ingredients of a democratic society. In non-democratic set-ups, such claims would not have

legal basis. Once the principle of individual freedom and dignity has been accepted in democracy, it is easier for women to wage a struggle against what is now unacceptable legally and morally.

- **Caste inequalities**: democracy in India has **strengthened the claims of the disadvantaged and discriminated castes** for equal status and equal opportunity. There are still instances of caste-based inequalities and atrocities, but these lack the moral and legal foundations.
- **Expectations and complaints**: democracy is a continuous process. As people get some benefits of democracy, they ask for more. **Expectations from democracy** keep rising, and people complain when they are not met. This is a sign of success: it shows people have become aware and critical; they have become **citizens** from subjects.

BOARD FAVOURITES

"How is democracy accountable, responsive and legitimate?" (5 marks), "Can democracy guarantee economic growth? Use the data", "Democracies have not reduced economic inequality: explain", "Two conditions for accommodating social diversity" (3 marks), "How does democracy promote dignity and freedom of citizens?". Always give a balanced view: strengths plus limitations.

Quick recap

- Democracy promotes equality, dignity, better decisions, conflict resolution and correction of mistakes.
- It gives accountable (transparent), responsive and legitimate government, though it may be slower.
- 1950–2000: dictatorships grew slightly faster (4.42%) than democracies (3.95%); difference among poor countries negligible.
- Political equality has not removed economic inequality and poverty.

- Accommodation needs majority working with minority and no permanent majority based on birth.
- Democracy promotes dignity of women and disadvantaged castes; rising expectations show its success.

Practice questions

1. The right and means of citizens to examine the process of decision-making is called
   (a) legitimacy (b) transparency (c) majoritarianism (d) federalism
2. Between 1950 and 2000, the average growth rate of all dictatorial regimes was
   (a) 3.95% (b) 4.28% (c) 4.42% (d) 5.10%
3. Which outcome of democracy is the weakest in practice?
   (a) Legitimacy of government (b) Dignity of citizens (c) Accommodation of social diversity (d) Reduction of economic inequality
4. Democracy is described as a legitimate government because
   (a) it is always efficient (b) it always reduces poverty (c) it is people's own government, elected by them (d) it never makes mistakes
5. For democracy to accommodate social diversity, it is necessary that
   (a) the majority always rules alone (b) rule by majority does not become rule by a majority community defined by birth (c) minorities are kept out of government (d) there is only one party
6. Rising complaints and expectations from democracy indicate that
   (a) democracy has failed completely (b) people want dictatorship (c) governments are illegitimate (d) people have become aware and critical citizens
7. "Democracy is an accountable, responsive and legitimate government." Explain.
8. "Democracy cannot guarantee economic growth and equality, yet it is preferred." Justify.

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. d 4. c 5. b 6. d 7. see notes 8. see notes